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HIS 101: Nigerian History to 1960 - States, Trade and Conquest

Chronology, evidence and the arguments historians actually have

FACULTY PRIMER

Faculty Primer

Faculty of Arts
History & International Studies | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

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Why this pack exists

This pack gives you the chronology first-year history demands, then shows the arguments behind it: pre-colonial state formation, the trans-Saharan and Atlantic trades, the mechanics of colonial conquest, indirect rule, and the nationalist movement up to independence.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Build a defensible chronology of Nigerian history to 1960.
- Compare pre-colonial political systems without ranking them.
- Explain how colonial administration reshaped economy and society.
- Evaluate competing historical interpretations.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Chronology you must hold

Dates are the skeleton of a history answer.

- Pre-colonial states: Kanem-Bornu, the Hausa city-states, Oyo, Benin, the Igbo segmentary societies.
- Trans-Saharan trade and the spread of Islam in the north.
- Atlantic slave trade and its demographic and political effects.
- Legitimate trade in palm oil and the Niger expeditions.
- Annexation of Lagos (1861) and the Royal Niger Company era.
- Amalgamation of 1914, indirect rule, nationalist parties, and independence in 1960.

Comparing political systems

Comparison needs criteria, not adjectives.

- Centralisation: emperor, oba, emir, or council of elders.
- Succession rules and the role of lineage.
- Taxation, tribute and military organisation.
- Gender and age-grade structures in governance.
- Religion and legitimacy.
- Trade linkages between regions before colonial contact.

> **Avoid the 'stateless' trap**
> Societies without kings were not without government. Describe the institutions that actually governed - councils, age grades, title societies.

Colonial rule and its arguments

Know the debate and its evidence.

- Indirect rule relied on existing authorities and reshaped them in the process.
- Cash crops, rail and taxation integrated Nigeria into an export economy.
- Mission education produced a new elite with its own grievances.
- Nationalism moved from cultural assertion to party politics.
- Historiographical debate: colonial emphasis versus African agency.
- Use primary sources critically: who wrote, for whom, and why?

Before colonial rule: states, trade and networks

Pre-colonial Nigeria contained several distinct political systems. The Sokoto Caliphate, consolidated after the jihad of 1804, was a federation of emirates under a caliph, administered through Islamic law, taxation and a scholarly class. The Oyo Empire governed through a king checked by a council of chiefs, with a cavalry-based military and an elaborate provincial structure. Benin had a centralised monarchy with titled societies and a craft guild system producing the bronzes that later became evidence in debates about African achievement.

Igbo communities are often described as "stateless", which is misleading. Many operated without a central king but through village assemblies, age grades, title societies and oracles that exercised judicial and political authority. The Arochukwu oracle network, for instance, was an economic and legal institution spanning a large region.

Long-distance trade connected these systems: trans-Saharan routes north, Atlantic trade south from the sixteenth century, and internal markets for salt, cloth, iron and kola. The Atlantic slave trade reshaped these economies over three centuries, and its abolition in the nineteenth century drove the expansion of palm oil production - the commodity that made the Niger Delta strategically valuable to Britain.